

Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



FOR THE STUDENTS, THE DAY BEGINS EARLY AT DAWN WITH PRAYERS, FOLLOWED BY RECITATION OF MANTRAS AND SHLOKAS BESIDES MARTIAL ARTS TRAINING AND EXERCISES

By Farzand Ahmed

For thousands of years, religious decree barred women from entering temples and chanting or listening to mantras. The law was scripted by Manu, the mythological ancestor of the human race in Hinduism. A strict section of the Brahminical order interpreted Manusmriti, the laws of Manu, as gospel. They quote Manu to provide credence to their claim: "For women, no sacramental rite is performed with sacred texts. Women destitute of strength and

knowledge of the Vedas are as impure as falsehood itself" and that "there is no ritual for Vedic verses for women". Some even equate women with shudras, the lowest in the Hindu caste hierarchy, and say that molten lead should be poured into women's ears should they hear the Vedas.

All that has been turned on its head at Shri Jigyasu Smarak Panini Kanya Mahavidyalaya, a Sanskrit college for girls in Varanasi. Manu's 5,000-year-old law is being challenged here, where almost a hundred girls sit down to perform havans while chanting Vedic hymns every morning. The college is a unique centre of Sanskrit teaching exclusively for girls where they are taught to practise all the 16 sanskaras (sanctifying or purificatory rites). "Some pundits had cleverly crafted '*stri-suradau nadhi yatam, iti shruti*' (it's said that women and Sudras can't recite and listen to Vedas) and inserted it in holy scriptures," says Acharya Nandita Shastri, a senior teacher at the college. "It then became a divine order. We teach the correct Hindu scriptures which nowhere say that women can't recite mantras or lead pujas." The mahavidyalaya is run on Vaidic Vichara (Vedic system) but is not confined to Brahmins. "We don't follow the Varna (caste) system as defined in Manusmriti," says Shastri. "We have Brahmins, Vaishyas (backward castes) and Shudras (Dalits) as well."

The school was founded in 1971 by Sanskrit scholar, Acharya Dr Pranja Devi, and his sister Medha Devi, the current principal. It started as a



pathshala (primary school) with just four students in a small house. Their efforts to change the way the scriptures are interpreted have been praised by Brahmins themselves. Professor Somnath Tripathi, who teaches ancient history at Varanasi's Sampurnananda Sanskrit University which conducts the examinations of the college, rejects the belief that only male Brahmins have the right to recite mantras. What the scriptures preached was yagna and jajman, one who pays for religious services to a priest or a Brahmin. Also, the concept of karmakanda (religious rites) was non-existent in ancient writings. "Since Sanskrit was in the hands of Brahmins,